Tips & Tricks

Kill your processes graphically

The *xkill* command closes the connections of a client to X server. Using the *xkill* command changes your mouse cursor into a 'kill' sign. Now when you click the left mouse button on any window that you want to kill, it gets killed. Note that this program is very dangerous, yet useful for aborting program windows that otherwise do not shut down.

—Arunprasad R, ararunprasad@gmail.com

Play songs from the command line

You can play any song file from the command line without using any player but a utility called SOX. More often than not, SOX is available in your distro's repository. You can install it in a Debian-based system as follows:

```
apt-get install sox
```

To play a song from the command line, use:

```
play song.mp3
```

...where song.mp3 is the path to your MP3 file. To stop playback, hit *Ctrl+C*.

If your song's file name contains spaces, specify the file name within double quotes. For example:

```
play "song 2.mp3"
```

When playing audio files, you can even specify more than one input file as follows:

```
play "song 2.mp3" "song 3.mp3" "song 5.mp3"
```

—Pramod, pramod@icsplindia.com

Check processes not run by you

Imagine the following scenario: you get yourself ready for a quick round of *Crack Attack* against a colleague at work, only to find the game drags to a halt just as you're about to beat your uppity subordinate. What could have happened to make your machine so slow? It must be some of those other users, stealing your precious CPU time with their scientific experiments, Web servers or other weird, geeky applications!

Okay, so let's list all the processes not being run by you. Just run the following command:

```
ps aux | grep -v `whoami`
```

Or, to be a little cleverer, why not just list the top ten time-wasters...

```
ps aux --sort=-%cpu | grep -m 11 -v `whoami`
```

It is probably best to run this as the root user, as this will filter out most of the vital background processes. Now that you have the information, you can simply kill their processes, but much more dastardly would be run *xeyes* on their desktop. Repeatedly!

—Pavan Kumar Nelanuthula, pavan.n@gmail.com

Driver information of Ethernet

You can use the following command to get information about the driver and firmware version of your Ethernet card as follows:

```
# ethtool -i eth0
```

A typical output for the command follows: